# EARLY NAVAL BATTLES AND THE RISE OF THE GREEKS



**Battle of Salamis**
This fanciful picture of the battle captures the spirit of the chaotic close-quarters duels that developed between pairs of ships. The ships' sails, however, would not have been raised during a Greek sea battle; all the propulsion was provided by the oars.

**ALTHOUGH THERE WERE** other seafaring peoples, notably the Phoenicians, around the coasts of the Mediterranean in ancient times, the development of early naval warfare is especially associated with the Greek city-states. Their wars against the Persians in the 5th century BCE and then against one another in the Peloponnesian War (431–404 BCE), generated sea battles large and small. The trireme, a powerful but nimble war galley armed with a ram at its prow, made naval combat into a contest of maneuver between teams of skilled oarsmen. The Greek cities—especially Athens—put impressive resources of money and manpower into their navies. At the battle against the Persians at Salamis there may have been as many as 34,000 oarsmen on the Greek side.

## EARLY SEA POWER

The first sea battle of which record exists occurred in 1210 BCE off the island of Cyprus. Nothing is known of it but the bare fact that the fleet of Hittite King Suppiluliumus II defeated the Cypriots. Our earliest depiction of naval forces in action comes from two decades later, in 1190 BCE, when the Egyptians fought the invaders known as the Sea People in the Nile Delta. The Sea People's naval force was apparently ambushed, for an Egyptian text states: "Those who entered the river mouths were like birds ensnared in a net." Egyptian archers on oared river vessels and on shore deluged the invaders' packed ships with arrows, before the pharaoh's galleys closed to allow soldiers with shields and spears to board them. There is no evidence that the vessels involved were specifically designed for warfare. This was a battle that could have been fought in similar fashion on land—except that on land it was always possible to run away. Other seagoing peoples in the eastern Mediterranean, such as the Minoans and Mycenaeans, probably fought their sea battles in much the same manner.

**Phoenician bireme**
The war galley shown on this Phoenician silver shekel of the 4th century BCE is a bireme—powered by two banks of oars rather than the three of a trireme.



The most skilled seafarers of ancient times were the Phoenicians and the Greeks. Their gifted boat-builders and sailors developed specialist warships that depended on experienced crews to operate successfully. In the 6th century BCE Phoenicians and Greeks came into conflict.

**War galleys under sail**
The oarsmen in a galley naturally took advantage of winds and tides to make their task easier when traveling long distances. Even so, they never ventured far from shore.

